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The Church Represented in the Marketplace

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Free media and discipleship resources for pastors, leaders, and growing disciples.

The Church Represented in the Marketplace

*most appropriate in urban contexts or emerging centers of economy

Pastors and church leaders have a vital role to play to equip and disciple men and women in the marketplace and partner with them to be catalysts for change. The church is more than a Sunday only meeting. The church is alive and active every day and should be represented in the world through all followers of Christ.

A. Importance of empowering the church in the Marketplace

Definitions of the Marketplace:

- The marketplace is the arena of business, education, and government. In a broader sense, the marketplace is almost everywhere outside the walls of a church.
- The marketplace is a seat of power and authority where societal change can take place.

Importance of the Marketplace:

- We have been given a clear mandate from Genesis 1 to subdue the Earth. This dominion mandate to steward all things for God's glory is still in effect and it applies to the marketplace. Genesis 1:28-30
- We have been given the Great Commission: We are also commanded to make disciples of all nations. Matthew 28:18-20; Mark 16:15
- Work is Worship: If someone is working in the marketplace to the glory of God, his or her work is SACRED! A.W. Tozer: "It is not WHAT a man does but WHY he does it that makes his work secular or sacred."

The Seven Spheres of cultural influence:

These seven spheres of influence represent the foundational elements of any society or culture. Each sphere of influence shapes the minds and perspectives of the people in that society. We are called to have an impact on culture, but these elements of society also impact believers. Whether that impact is Godly or not is determined by those who hold power and control over these mountains. We must raise up Godly leaders to have influence in these areas:

1. Government
2. Family
3. Education
4. Church
5. Media
6. Art & Entertainment
7. Business

Economics is the engine that runs all seven of these cultural mountains. It is vital to have Godly marketplace leaders driving this engine. Globalization is God's plan. He is using globalization to connect people in unprecedented ways. There is a great opportunity to make an impact.

B. Pastors are equippers and the church is the equipping center

1. The Church is the equipping center. It is a primary function of pastors and teachers to "prepare God's people for works of service." (Ephesians 4:11-13)
2. The Marketplace is a mission field! By training businesspeople to be ministers in the marketplace pastors can greatly expand the Kingdom of God. Statistically, businesspeople come face to face with many more lost people on a weekly basis than a pastor.
3. The harvest is ripe, but the workers are few. (Luke 10:2)
4. The goal is to equip leaders in our churches who can carry out their calling and extend God's Kingdom in the church, the community, the workplace, and the world. Equip them to be equippers, disciple to make disciples.
5. Connection with the local church should result in believers receiving spiritual tools to accomplish societal transformation for God's kingdom outside the church walls.

Consider your process of discipleship as an opportunity to engage and equip believers for effectiveness in their spheres of influence.

All of humanity shares these common questions:

- How can I provide for my family?
- How can I live in relative peace and safety for my family?
- How can I have meaningful relationships?
- How can the system I live in provide security, justice and economic opportunity?

Kingdom business leaders can be equipped to help answer these questions. That is why intentionally raising up Godly, effective business leaders (laity) is so vital.

C. How to equip business leaders in the church

Teach business leaders to be fishers of men.

In fishing, it is vital to use the right bait. Fish will not change their feeding habits. Christians must demonstrate how to live successfully on the earth. Economic issues are universal bait. We must apply God's word practically to our spheres of influence.

As the businessperson is trained and equipped by the church, he or she can more effectively "fish" in the marketplace. Train business leaders to have a biblical perspective on the common questions of humanity.

Validate and teach about the ministry of the marketplace (money, corruption, Godly relationships and leadership):

- From the pulpit
- In small groups
- In the community

Foster and encourage the call to business:

- Help businesspeople see their work as ministry
- Encourage them to put a "ministry plan" into their business plan
- Preach the doctrine of work as worship from the pulpit and in small groups
- Lay hands on business leaders and commission them

As a pastor or ministry leader, you should intentionally build relationships:

- Choose a few business leaders to meet with regularly
- Meet them individually at their place of business. (Jesus went to where the disciples were when He called them)
- Discuss and study relevant issues to the marketplace
- Help marketplace leaders see, think, and plan multi-generationally

Learn from marketplace leaders:

- Allow for their input and ideas related to church management

- Conduct the business of your ministry or church with integrity; manage money and people well

Things and attitudes to avoid:

- Treating businesspeople as “cash registers”
- Treating businesspeople as a necessary evil or secular
- Viewing money as ungodly
- Avoiding businesspeople
- Being fake or manipulative

D. Significant results can be expected

1. God’s people will begin to establish the Kingdom of God in their spheres of influence—outside the walls of the church
2. Multitudes of Kingdom Businesses will be established around the world.
3. New capital will be generated by God’s people for God’s purposes
4. Local Churches that become Equipping Centers will see:
 - Maturity of believers
 - Discipleship movements in the workplace
 - Relevant impact in their cities and communities
 - Lost people attracted to the Church
 - Kingdom projects that reach beyond the four walls of the church
 - Growth in numbers and finances
 - Over time, the level of “spiritual capital” will increase in the nation (integrity, justice, righteousness, prosperity)
5. The church planter is called to equip all believers with spiritual truths that enable them to be effective salt and light in the world.
 - Commit to preach and teach about the marketplace, money, and work from the pulpit of your church.
 - Commit to disciple a group of marketplace leaders in your church.
 - Commit to conduct the business of your church or ministry with integrity and asking for input from the marketplace leaders in your church.

- Commission business leaders to take the Seven Spheres of Influence for the Kingdom of God.

This article was provided by Joshua Nations (JoshuaNations.org).